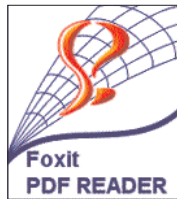


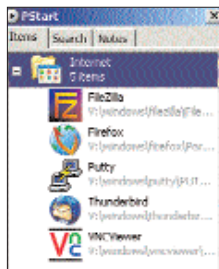
years old. It also looks just like Adobe's Reader, so once again, you aren't going to feel lost. We recommend this not only as a portable application, but as a credible replacement for Adobe Reader altogether.



The Start Menu

It isn't fair that road warriors shouldn't have the benefit of a Start Menu, is it? PStart is a program that sits in the system tray and gives you your own menu that lets you choose which application you want to run. It even hunts down executable files on your drive, so you don't even need to make any manual entries—once you've put all your applications on your drive, just select the "Scan for Executables" function to create your own portable start menu.

You can find all these and more portable software on this month's CD and DVD.



Packing It All In

Once you've decided on what you're going to put in your drive, installation is usually simple enough. Most of these applications come as ZIP archives, so all you need to do is extract them to the drive.

For the ones that come with installers, you could either install them directly to the drive, or install them to your Windows drive and copy the program folder from "C:\Program Files" (or wherever you installed the application) to the drive.

The Next Step—The Mobile Geek

We have, of course, assumed that you'll be working on PCs with Windows loaded on them, so you'll still have to bear with whatever settings the owner of the PC has kept in store for you. If, however, you wish for the same computing experience on every PC you ever sit at, you could go a step further and put an entire OS on the USB stick! We're talking about Damn Small Linux (DSL), a 50 MB Linux distribution that fits more than neatly into a portable drive (find it on this month's DVD). "It's probably got no GUI," you might say, before we tell you that it does come with the FluxBox window manager, as well as a host of applications including the über-light Dillo browser. On the hardware front, you will need a bootable USB drive (most drives today are), and the motherboard of the PC you're working on must support booting from a USB device.

Of course, you will have to learn the basics of Linux and get used to the user interface, but once you do, every PC you ever work on will be like your own.

So with everything so eerily close to the ultimate vision of on-demand computing, are you still going to wait? ■

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